

4.2.10 DirectX

A graphics programming API proprietary to Microsoft. Games based on DirectX can only be played on a Microsoft OS. DirectX 10 is the latest version of this API. To be able to experience software written in DirectX 10, one requires Microsoft's latest OS (Windows Vista) and a DirectX 10 compatible graphics card.

4.2.11 Dual Display

This is a feature of graphics cards that can power two monitors at the same time. In the case of analogue monitors, the graphics card will require two RAMDACs. In case of LCD monitors, two DVI ports are needed. The output image can be split across these monitors, creating one large image.

4.2.12 FPS

A Frame is a static image created by rendering. To give an illusion of motion, many frames are constantly rendered. Frames per second (fps) is a measure of the rendering speed. A higher frames-per-second rate of rendering ensures (an illusion of) smoother movement. This is also a measure of the computational abilities of a graphics card.

4.2.13 Frame Buffer

A buffer is a temporary storage area. The Frame Buffer refers to the RAM on the graphics card that is used to store the frames that have already been rendered by the GPU.

4.2.14 GPGPU

General Purpose GPUs refer to those GPUs that can also be used to perform non-graphics work. GPUs have increased in computational prowess to such an extent that they are capable of overtaking most CPUs in their ability to manage numerical—specifically decimal—data, which forms the bulk of graphics data that they are specially designed for. The GPGPU concept seeks to utilise this power of the GPU to perform general tasks that are heavy on number crunching, like weather simulations and space data manipulation. The fact that newer cards are increasingly programmable, allowing the developer to use them for custom purposes, helps the cause.